

**United States Geological Survey (USGS)
Request for Information (RFI) and Sources Sought
Economic Analysis of the Earth Mapping Resources Initiative (Earth MRI)**

General Information

Tracking Number:	140G0126Q0082 (SAM.gov) RFI1802859 (ebuy.gsa.gov)
Release of RFI Date:	03/26/2026
Response Submission Date:	04/14/2026
NAICS Code:	<u>541611 (Administrative Management and General Management Consulting Services)</u>
GSA MAS Schedule Category (SIN)	<u>541611 (Professional Services/Business Administrative Services)</u>

This is a Request for Information (RFI). This is not a solicitation for a contract award. This action is for market research (information) purposes only, is not a request for proposals or quotations, and does not obligate the Government in any way. A solicitation may or may not result from this request. The Government will not reimburse the respondents for any costs associated with the information submitted in response to this request. The Government will treat each submission in confidence. Responses will assist the USGS in understanding available analytical approaches and organizational capabilities relevant to conducting an economic analysis of the USGS Earth Mapping Resources Initiative (Earth MRI) within the Geology, Energy, and Minerals Mission Area (GEMMA).

I. Introduction

The Nation's geologic framework is under-mapped relative to other developed nations. We lack the systematic, high-quality data needed to understand our nation's geologic resources and address its changing mineral needs. In 2019, the USGS launched the Earth MRI to answer this challenge by transforming and modernizing the Nation's mapping of the surface and subsurface. Furthermore, E.O. 14154, Unleashing American Energy (January 20, 2025) directly calls on the USGS to "accelerate the ongoing, detailed geologic mapping of the United States, with a focus on locating previously unknown deposits of critical minerals" through the Earth MRI.

In 2021, Earth MRI received \$320 million in supplemental funding to spend over five years (FY22-FY26) from the Infrastructure Investment and Jobs Act (IIJA). IIJA funding dramatically accelerated the pace of the program and the scope of data collection. The USGS partners with state geological surveys, private industry, federal agencies, tribes and others to prioritize work and to collect and disseminate data. Through these partnerships, Earth MRI leverages both national-scale coordination and local expertise to maximize the value and impact of data collection.

Earth MRI is collecting an unprecedented volume of foundational geoscience data across the full extent of the nation that presently includes geophysical, geochemical, hyperspectral, topographic, geologic and mine waste data of the surface and subsurface. The USGS is providing a crucial national perspective of the nation's geology and mineral resources by making these data publicly available and ready for integration and analysis. Earth MRI data collection is presently focused in areas with potential critical and industrial minerals, including in mine wastes. Additionally, the same data provide essential information about groundwater and energy resources, potential natural hazards, and infrastructure needs in these areas, informing management of wide-ranging natural resources. In some applications, Earth MRI datasets may also be used in combination with other publicly available federal datasets, including satellite-based Earth observation systems such as Landsat, to improve understanding of geologic features, surface conditions, and resource potential.

USGS is exploring approaches for conducting an economic analysis of the Earth MRI to better understand the economic value and estimated return on investment associated with Earth MRI activities and data products. This RFI is intended to inform the USGS about vendor interest, capabilities, and experience in performing these services.

II. Analytical Considerations

USGS seeks information on analytical approaches and technical expertise relevant to evaluating the economic value and benefits associated with Earth MRI activities, data, maps, and other products, including both current program outputs and potential future benefits associated with expanded data collection. The analysis may evaluate direct and indirect economic benefits associated with Earth MRI, including the value of Earth MRI data products used in science, operational applications, and decision-making. The study may examine how these data products support mineral resource assessments, resource exploration activities and investments, infrastructure planning, hazard understanding, and other applications supported by improved geologic information. Improved geologic information reduces uncertainty and risk associated with mineral exploration and may motivate, direct, and accelerate investment and (or) resource development decisions. In many cases, improved geologic information may create both direct and indirect economic value by reducing uncertainty and improving the quality of information available for decision-making, which may influence resource exploration and related investment decisions, capital allocation, and resource development planning.

In addition to market impacts, the analysis may consider non-market benefits associated with publicly available Earth MRI data products. Where feasible, these benefits should be quantified using appropriate economic approaches. In cases where benefits cannot be readily monetized, qualitative assessment may be appropriate to describe the broader value of Earth MRI. The analysis may also consider how Earth MRI data may be used, or may increasingly be used, in future applications, in combination with other publicly available datasets, including satellite-based Earth observation systems such as Landsat, and how integration of geologic and remotely sensed datasets may enhance interpretation of surface conditions, resource potential, and related decision-making.

Multiple analytical approaches may be appropriate for evaluation of the value of publicly available geoscience data programs, and respondents may describe approaches that capture how current/future Earth MRI datasets influence exploration activities, investment decisions, resource management, and other applications supported by improved geologic information. Economic approaches should be consistent with Office of Management and Budget (OMB) guidance for economic analysis, where possible. Findings from the analysis will inform program planning, investment decisions, and evaluation of future Earth MRI activities.

III. Data Collection Considerations

Understanding how Earth MRI activities, data, maps, and other products are used and applied may involve collecting information from data users and subject matter experts. Responses should place emphasis on applications related to mineral exploration and development, while also considering the broader range of users and use cases supported by Earth MRI. The specific type of data collection would depend on the analytical methods and study design proposed, and not all activities described below would necessarily be required. Potential options might include user engagement methods such as surveys, interviews, workshops, focus groups, etc. to inform the economic analysis and study design. Some of these are subject to the Paperwork Reduction Act (PRA). Contractor responsibilities would include development of data collection methodology, instrument design, sampling strategies, and related preparatory work supporting the economic analysis. The contractor would also prepare technical materials supporting the PRA information collection request (ICR) package for OMB review, including descriptions of data collection design and methodology. USGS would manage the PRA submission and approval process. The contractor would provide technical support during the OMB review, including

responding to questions related to the proposed data collection design or methodology. Data collection activities may occur in phases as study design and PRA approvals progress. Work on this effort would involve collaboration between USGS and the selected organization throughout study development, data collection, analysis, etc.

IV. Information Requested

Organizations interested in responding to this notice are invited to provide information addressing the topics below. Respondents should organize their responses according to the topics listed below.

1. Organization Information

Provide:

- Organization Name,
- Organization Type,
- Point of Contact (name, email address, and phone number)
- Business Size under NAICS 541611
- If your organization possess a GSA MAS contract, specify the contract number.

2. Capabilities

Briefly describe your organization's capabilities relevant to the economic analysis described in this notice. Relevant expertise may include, but not limited to, the following:

- Economic analysis and valuation of public programs
- Natural resource economics
- Mineral or energy market analysis
- Economic impact analysis or program evaluation
- Social science methods supporting economic data collection
- Geoscience expertise relevant to mineral resources, geologic mapping, or related Earth science disciplines

USGS is particularly interested in teams combining economic expertise with knowledge of energy and mineral resource industries, including mineral exploration and development dynamics. Experience or familiarity with private-sector decision-making related to mineral exploration and resource development is relevant. Experience evaluating the use or integration of geoscience datasets with satellite-based Earth observation data, such as Landsat, may also be relevant.

3. Relevant Experience

Describe prior work relevant to the capabilities described above. Responses may include work performed by key team members as well as the organization. Briefly describe the scope of the work and the role of the organization or team members involved. Include photographs, videos, or links of specific examples of similar work/projects and include publicly available contract details (scope of work, agency, contract number, total price) for work completed for the Federal Government.

4. Economic Valuation

Describe economic approaches that may be appropriate for evaluation of the value of Earth MRI datasets and related geologic information. Where possible, explain how the proposed methodology would estimate or measure economic value, benefits, or impacts associated with Earth MRI, including how the analysis would inform practical decision-making or program evaluation. Responses may discuss relevant theoretical frameworks as appropriate but should emphasize how the proposed approach could be applied in practice. Indicate any experience applying economic approaches consistent with OMB guidance for federal economic analyses.

5. Data Collection

Describe experience designing and conducting data collection activities such as surveys, interviews, workshops, or focus groups used to support economic analyses. Experience engaging with industry stakeholders or mineral resource experts is particularly relevant.

6. Other (optional)

Please provide any additional relevant details that may be beneficial to the USGS.

V. Analytical Questions

Respondents may address the questions below.

1. What economic frameworks or analytical methods are most appropriate for evaluating the economic value or benefits of Earth MRI activities, data, maps, and other products?
2. How could these methods estimate or measure the economic benefits of improved geologic information, including impacts on investment decisions, resource development, and other planning or management decisions.
3. What data sources, indicators, or empirical evidence could help evaluate economic impacts associated with the use of Earth MRI activities, data, maps, and other products by the private sector or other users?
4. How have previous studies evaluated or quantified non-market benefits associated with publicly available geoscience datasets, and what approaches could be applied to Earth MRI?
5. Beyond direct economic benefits associated with resource development and related activities, how could an economic evaluation of Earth MRI capture the value of co-benefits and other indirect or non-market benefits associated with improved geologic information? Examples of applications include but are not limited to the following: land-use and infrastructure planning, environmental evaluation, hazard mitigation, workforce development, technology innovation, etc. How might the analysis also consider how improved geologic information reduces uncertainty and risk in investment, planning, and management decisions?
6. What methodological challenges arise when evaluating the economic value of large public science or geoscience programs, and how would your organization/team address those challenges?
 - a. What analytical methods or frameworks are most appropriate for addressing these challenges in practice?
 - b. How do data limitations – including limited access to privately held or non-public data relevant to resource development and investment decisions – affect such analyses? What strategies would your team use to address these limitations, including acquiring, deriving, or developing data inputs suitable for rigorous economic evaluation?
7. To what extent could the combined use of Earth MRI with other publicly available datasets, including satellite-based Earth observation systems such as Landsat, enhance the value or decision-making utility for resource management, planning, or other applications.

VI. Rough Order of Magnitude / Level-of-Effort Information

Respondents should provide planning-level estimates of rough order-of-magnitude cost ranges and approximate durations for conducting the economic analysis similar to the one described in this notice. USGS anticipates that a future effort may involve multiple phases of work, such as development of an analytical framework and study design; design of user engagement or data collection activities; preparation of materials supporting PRA submission; implementation of data collection activities; and economic analysis and reporting. The specific activities within these phases will depend on the analytical methods proposed, and the scope of the work within each phase may vary accordingly. Respondents should describe approximate cost and duration ranges for major phases of work. Some phases of work may occur sequentially depending on PRA timelines. USGS will manage the PRA submission process, with contractor support during OMB review as needed. These estimates are requested for market research and planning purposes only and should not be interpreted as a request for formal pricing or proposals.

VII. Instructions for Respondents

1. Concise but sufficiently detailed responses are encouraged. Respondents should organize their responses according to the sections outlined in the RFI.

2. Responses shall be submitted via email to christopher_kuhn@ios.doi.gov by 04/14/2026 at 4:00PM EDT. The subject line should state “RFI 140G0126Q0082 USGS GEMMA – Earth MRI Economic Analysis”. Respondents may submit questions for clarification. Questions shall be sent via email to christopher_kuhn@ios.doi.gov. The subject line should state “RFI 140G0126Q0082 USGS GEMMA – Earth MRI Economic Analysis”. **NOTE: This RFI is posted to both SAM.gov and GSA eBuy (ebuy.gsa.gov). If your organization possesses a GSA MAS contract, respond to the RFI in the eBuy system (ebuy.gsa.gov) under the identifier RFI1802859. Contractors should not respond to both RFIs.**
3. Responses are limited to 10 pages (excluding cover page and contact information).
4. The information is requested for planning purposes only. Only material suitable for internal government distribution shall be submitted. Any restricted information should be marked accordingly. The Government will protect all restricted information received from respondents, and distribution of any material will be based on a strict need-to-know basis. No classified material should be provided. Submittals identified as containing such material shall be destroyed and not considered further.
5. It is emphasized that this RFI is for planning and information purposes only and is not to be construed as a commitment by the Government to enter into a contractual agreement, nor will the Government pay for information provided.
6. As part of the Government’s market research process, the Government may hold further exchanges with none, some, or all respondents depending on the Government's needs. Please be sure the RFI response contains the correct contact information for this potential communication.

END RFI